

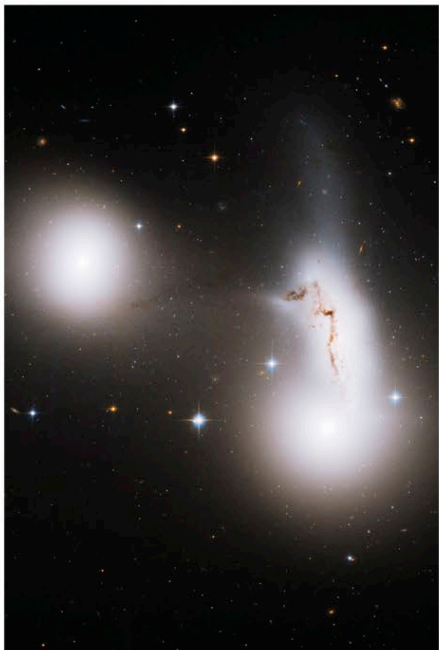
PISCIS AUSTRINUS

THE SOUTHERN FISH

A SMALL, APPROXIMATELY FISH-SHAPED RING OF FAINT STARS, PISCIS AUSTRINUS IS ONE OF THE MOST SOUTHERLY OF THE 48 CONSTELLATIONS DESCRIBED BY THE ASTRONOMERS OF ANCIENT GREECE. IT CAN MOST EASILY BE LOCATED BY ITS BRILLIANT STAR, FOMALHAUT.

Piscis Austrinus is said to be the parent of the two fishes that comprise the less obvious constellation Pisces. It is notable for its bright star Fomalhaut, the 18th-brightest star in the night sky. Fomalhaut's name comes from the Arabic for "fish's mouth," which is where it is located in the constellation. This star is also celebrated as the first known to

have a disk of material around it. The disk, which is several times the diameter of our own Solar System, is in the process of forming into planets. One such planet has already been spotted; called Fomalhaut b, it takes about 1,700 years to orbit its parent star. The constellation's other stars are comparatively faint, and has no deep-sky objects of note.



△ HCG 90 (Hickson Compact Group 90)
These three galaxies are part of HCG 90, a tight cluster of 16 galaxies about 110 million light-years away. Two are elliptical galaxies; the third is a dusty spiral galaxy that has been distorted by interaction with the closest of the ellipticals. The spiral is being stretched and pulled apart before being engulfed by the other two. Eventually, all three will probably merge to form one super galaxy.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 60

Brightest stars Fomalhaut (α) 1.2, Epsilon (ε) 4.2

Genitive Piscis Austrini

Abbreviation PsA

Highest in sky at 10pm September–October

Fully visible 53°N–90°S

CHART 3

MAIN STARS

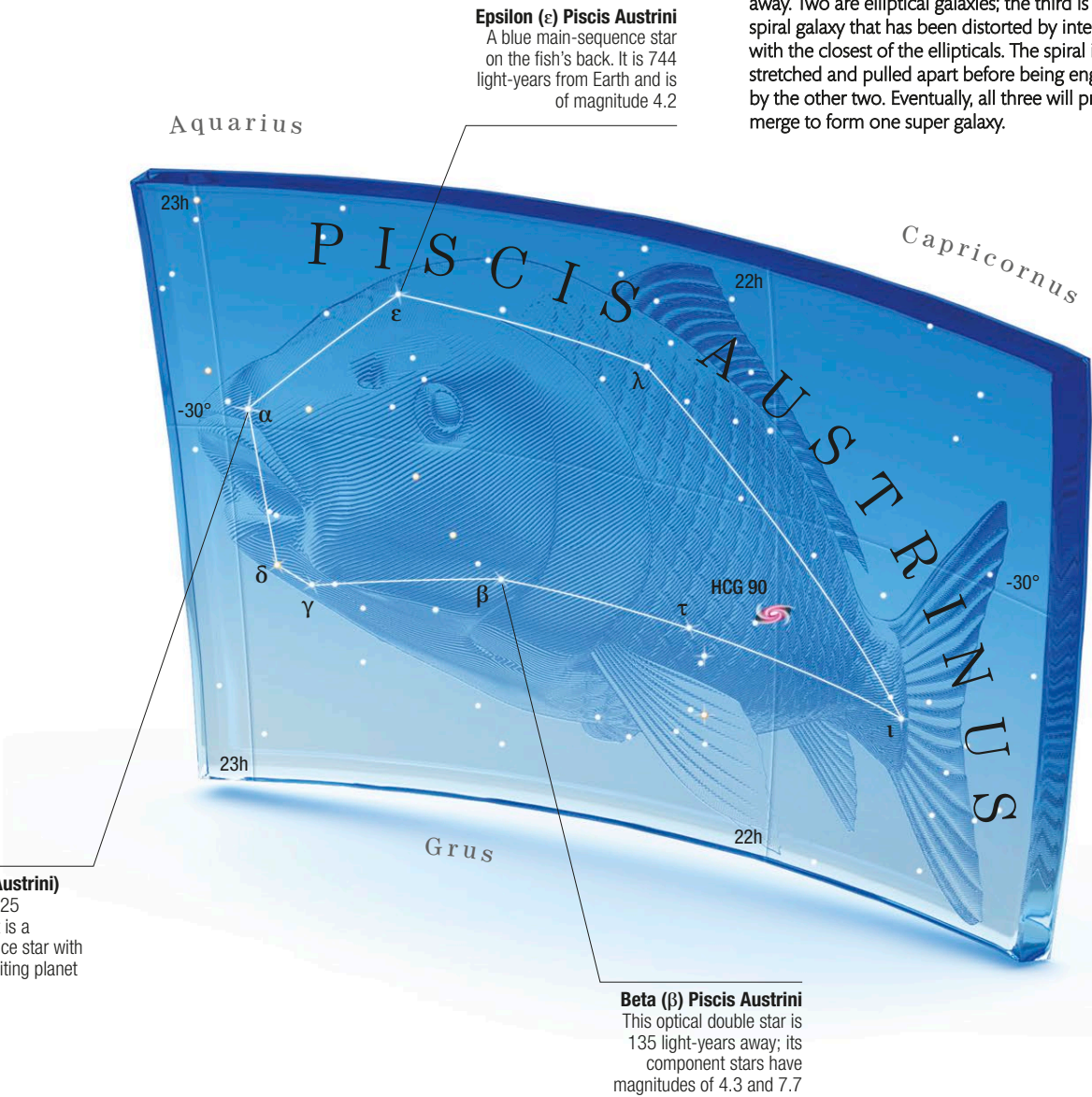
Fomalhaut Alpha (α) Piscis Austrini
Blue-white main-sequence star
☼ 1.2 ↔ 25 light-years

Epsilon (ε) Piscis Austrini
Blue main-sequence star
☼ 4.2 ↔ 744 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Debris disk around Fomalhaut
Ring of planet-forming material

HCG 90 (Hickson Compact Group 90)
Compact group of galaxies



Fomalhaut (α Piscis Austrini)
This brilliant star is only 25 light-years from Earth; it is a blue-white main-sequence star with a debris disk and an orbiting planet

Epsilon (ε) Piscis Austrini
A blue main-sequence star on the fish's back. It is 744 light-years from Earth and is of magnitude 4.2

Beta (β) Piscis Austrini
This optical double star is 135 light-years away; its component stars have magnitudes of 4.3 and 7.7